

once Windows 7 is ready for consumers. A quick look at some numbers online reveals that in this sort of level playing field, Chrome is doing better than IE 8 in terms of market share. (Though to be fair we must consider that IE8 is still in beta.) The battle which will now ensue to become the next browser of choice will definitely be interesting.

Coming to the question of whether Chrome will be adopted by the masses, it all depends on user preference. Users tend to get pretty attached to the little niche utilities that each browser has. The noticeable lack of add-on support in Chrome is one of the many items people who haven't made the switch typically cited. But regardless of how ready the browser is in the non-beta *avatar*, this latest move puts them in a good position to take advantage of OEMs. Having Chrome pre-installed on machines will quickly boost its usage stats.

INDIA GETS 3G

3Gs are better than one

MTNL recently announced the launch of 3G services in Delhi. Interestingly enough, it was inaugurated by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh by receiving a video call from Telecom Minister A Raja. We would've expected one of the private players to be the first one off the block, but what is important is the reaction the announcement has evoked. Message boards were actively speculating what kind of plans would be available, whether there would be a

data limit, and if so, would it be ridiculously low thereby defeating the whole point of 3G. For the uninitiated, 3G will allow operators to offer high-end services such as faster downloads of video clips, movie trailers and music files, video calls, interactive gaming and even streaming video. The existing telecom services in India operate on the 2G spectrum. The process for the auction of 3G licences in India kicks off in January 2009. But before we get on to the nitty-gritties, two issues must be addressed. First, of the 300 million mobile users in India, how many have 3G phones? These high-end phones cost more than Rs. 11,000 at the least. And out of all the things 3G enables you to do, how much of it will you really use? Perhaps the average Indian mobile user may want to watch a T20 match on the go rather than video call someone. In any case, 3G users will still be a small minority, at least initially. The second issue is shortage of spectrum availability in many circles at peak times. Service, is after all, as good as the calls it allows you to make, so we don't want any lagging issues there. Coming back to the licence auctioning, under existing guidelines, the successful 3G auction bidders will have to pay Rs 1,651 crore for a UASL licence that entitles them to offer all communication services. The 3G hype also brings up the longstanding battle between 3G and WiMax technologies. WiMax stands for Worldwide Interoperability for Microwave Access. It can also be used to provide voice services and rivals 3G as both the platforms are used

for similar applications. According to the Department of Telecom (DoT), the 2.1-GHz band will be used for 3G, while 2.3 GHz and 2.5 GHz have been earmarked for WiMax. Ericsson — the biggest supporter and equipment vendor of 3G — is laying claims on the 2.3 GHz spectrum band, which is meant for WiMax.

BAD BOYS - WHAT'CHA GONNA DO?

War on Piracy v2.0

It seems the bigwigs at RIAA are ready to try out just about anything to stem the piracy biz. First they began by suing people who downloaded music. That meant suing just about every person on planet earth right? They managed to sue 30,000 accused file sharers in the last five years. Clearly it wasn't working, so the music industry said "hey wait a minute, since so many people are downloading, viewing and

listening to copyrighted content, why not try to squeeze some ads in there." Accordingly, all such content on Myspace and YouTube wasn't necessarily pulled down. Instead, the original owners could just choose to put ads on it. Now in its latest installment against piracy, the Recording Industry Association of America (RIAA) has announced that it will work with internet service providers to sever abusers' net connections. Just to clarify, abuser here means you. Yes, you with the 20 GB MP3 collection! Under the new plan, RIAA will send notices to ISPs that identify the IP addresses of suspected file sharers. ISPs will then send warnings to their customers and then cut them off if the users fail to curb their illegal downloads. Details are still being worked out, but most reports said downloaders might lose their net connection after the third notice. The termination could last anywhere from three months to a year. But it

